Hinge questions

Deciding whether to move on

Use a hinge question at a decision point where students' answers should change what happens next. Plan the question and the teaching response together.

How to do it well

1 Plan the hinge in advance. Choose a pivotal concept and build plausible distractors from common misconceptions rather than random errors.

2 Ask it after a small teaching chunk. Place the question just before the lesson would otherwise move into the next explanation or practice demand.

3 Protect independent commitment. Give silent thinking time, keep the answer hidden and collect a whole-class response before partner discussion where initial diagnosis matters.

4 Scan choices and reasoning. Look for patterns, then invite pupils to explain why an option was attractive before revealing the correct answer.

5 Make the instructional decision. Move on when understanding is sufficiently secure; otherwise re-explain the identified misconception, use a different example or extend guided practice.

6 Recheck and refine. Test the same concept in a related form and later improve distractors that did not reveal the intended thinking.

What this sounds like

"Choose privately and prepare your reason. We will use the responses to decide whether we are ready for the next example or need to revisit this distinction."

Classroom example. Before a new stage in a calculation, a hinge question checks the relationship needed for that stage. Each option represents a different likely misconception. Independent choices reveal a shared error, so the teacher pauses, contrasts the methods and asks a fresh question. The planned next task changes because of the evidence.

Top tips that make the technique work

Identify the hinge. Choose a concept that students need before the next task or explanation will make sense.

Match each distractor to an error. An option should tell you what needs clarifying, not just whether the answer is wrong.

Collect independent answers first. Discussion can improve learning afterwards, but initial private commitment gives cleaner diagnostic evidence.

Decide your likely responses. Plan what you will do for a common misconception, mixed understanding and broadly secure answers.

Ask a fresh follow-up. The response after repair should require application, not memorisation of the original option.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Place the question before a consequential increase in demand.	A quiz item with no effect on the next teaching move.
Inspect reasoning and the pattern of choices.	Automatically moving on when a fixed percentage is correct.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Hinge Questions | Barton - Diagnostic questions